

A Network-Based Approach to the Preservation of Born-Digital Archives

A shared solution to a common challenge in the cultural heritage sector

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THE CHALLENGE

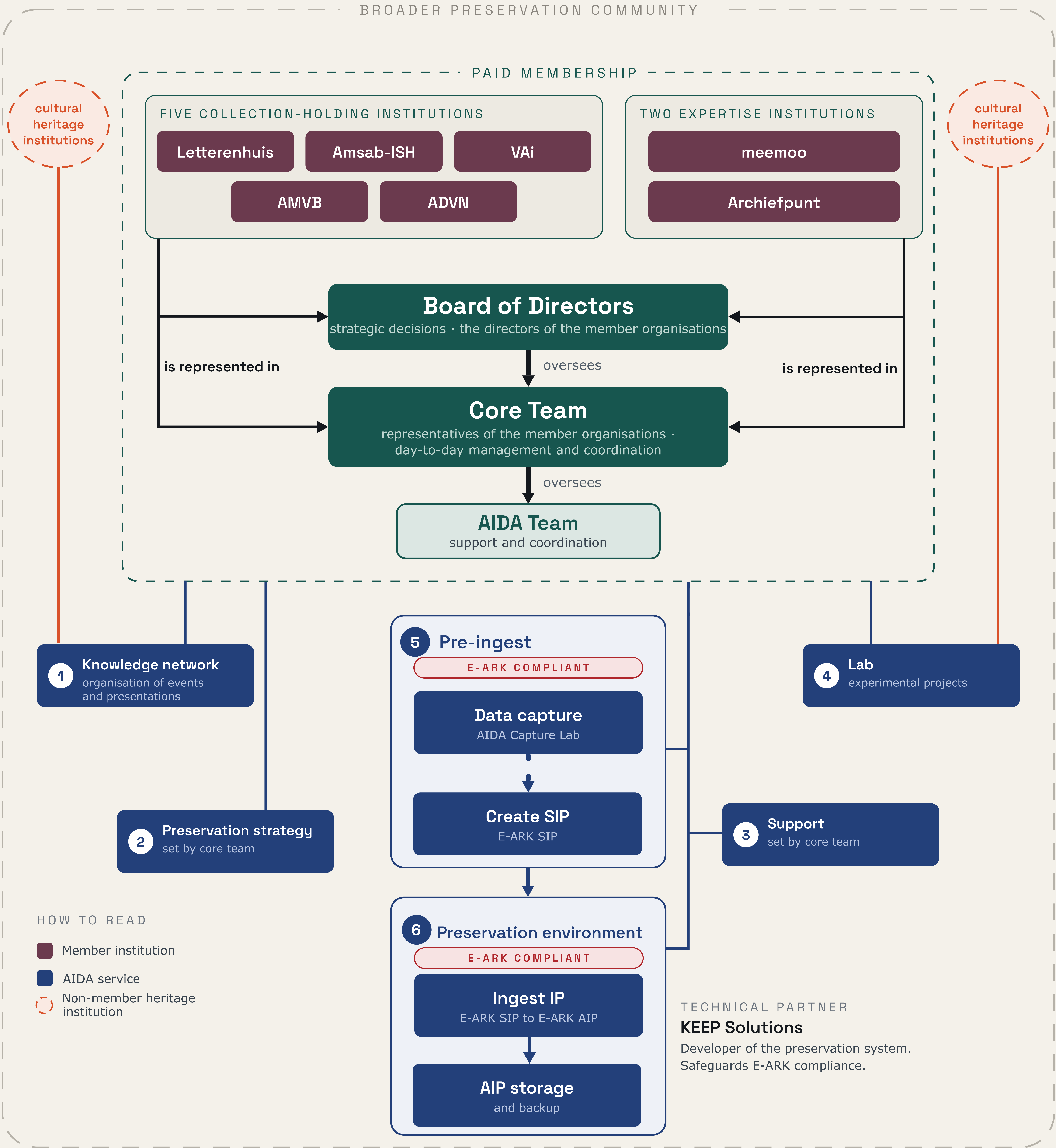
Heritage institutions receive more born-digital archives every year, but most lack the resources, the skills and the tools to preserve them. The solutions come from the IT sector, which rarely knows the daily reality of an archive. Needs are assumed rather than asked, and systems get built that do not answer the real requirements of the sector.

THE APPROACH

AIDA is a consortium of heritage organisations that pools knowledge and resources to preserve born-digital private archives and collections (DPAC). Seven organisations — five collection-holding institutions and two expertise institutions — share the cost, the development and the results. The services are provided by the partners, for the partners.

How AIDA Works

The AIDA governance model is built on shared ownership and an active network of partners, with a strong emphasis on autonomy from technical suppliers and on building expertise among the partners. AIDA delivers six services: four run across the whole network, two form the technical chain that carries an archive from capture to long-term storage.



What the Network Gains

01

Standards embedded by design

Format validation, metadata enrichment and integrity checks are part of the workflow from the outset, not added afterwards.

02

Open-source, vendor break-out

AIDA uses technology that is open, free and well documented, and agrees an exit scenario in advance. No member is locked to a single supplier.

03

Economies of scale

Sharing development costs and pooling expertise puts infrastructure within reach of institutions that could not fund it alone.

04

Shared ownership

Members are represented in the bodies that decide on the preservation strategy, the technical roadmap and the cost of the solution.

AIDA works cooperatively: the preservation environment is built and maintained by the partners themselves, from a shared interest and with a say in every choice.